SOC140 Phishing Investigation Report

Suspicious Task Scheduler alert

Case reference SOC140 | Environment LetsDefend training scenario

Executive assessment

The case is assessed as a true positive phishing attempt. The walkthrough records that the message was blocked before delivery. The available findings support prevention at the email layer; they do not establish a compromised user device or successful persistence. Closure should depend on checking the wider message scope and retaining the supporting evidence.

Recorded findings

The alert dates to 21 March 2021. The message used the subject “COVID19 Vaccine” and a suspicious attachment. The sender was aaronluo@cmail.carleton.ca, the recipient was marked@letsdefend.io, and the source IP was 189.162.189.159. A sender search returned three messages to different recipients.

The lab reports 30 VirusTotal detections and a malicious Hybrid Analysis verdict for the supplied file identifier. Logs show traffic to 172.16.20.3 on TCP port 25, identified as an Exchange server. Reviewed process and terminal history showed no suspicious activity.

Indicators for investigation

Use these values as search pivots, preserving the original fields in the evidence export. An address appearing in an alert does not, by itself, identify the person responsible.

Field	Value
Email sender	aaronluo@cmail.carleton.ca
Email recipient	marked@letsdefend.io
Source IP	189.162.189.159
Mail server	172.16.20.3
Reported file identifier	72c812cf21909a48eb9cceb9e04b865d

Analyst interpretation

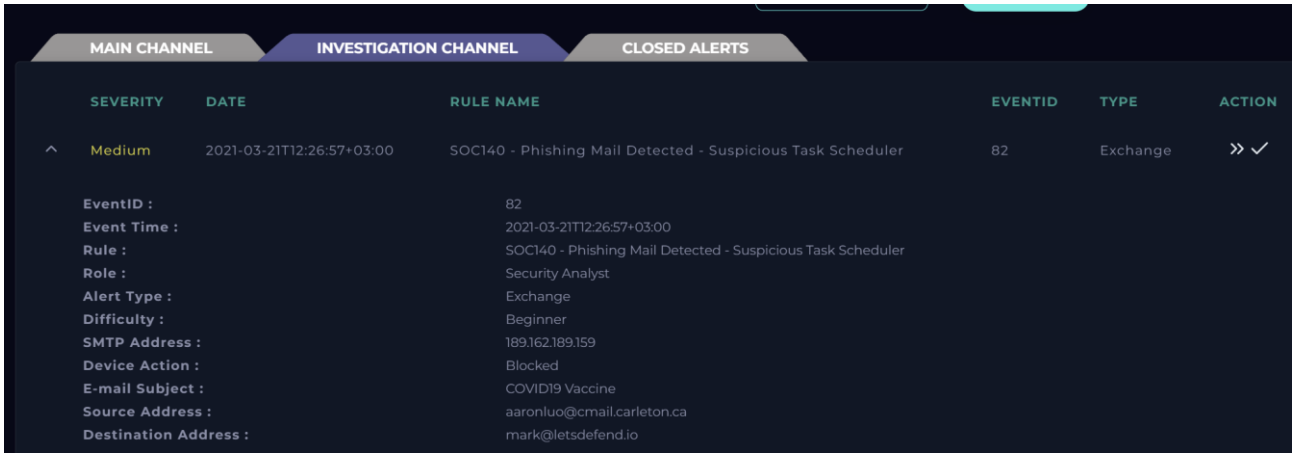
The strongest basis for the verdict is the combination of a suspicious attachment, reported malware reputation, and the recorded mail disposition. Reputation results should be retained with their analysis dates, because vendor counts can change. A reputation label alone should not be used to name a malware family or describe capabilities that have not been observed.

The supplied file identifier contains 31 hexadecimal characters. A standard MD5 digest requires 32. Treat this value as unverified and obtain the full digest from the original attachment record before using it for blocking or declaring a match. Record the algorithm and calculate a SHA256 digest from a safely handled sample if available.

The alert name does not prove scheduled task execution. Before making that claim, obtain the task name, action, trigger, account, creation time, and related process events. Without those artifacts, describe scheduled task activity as unconfirmed.

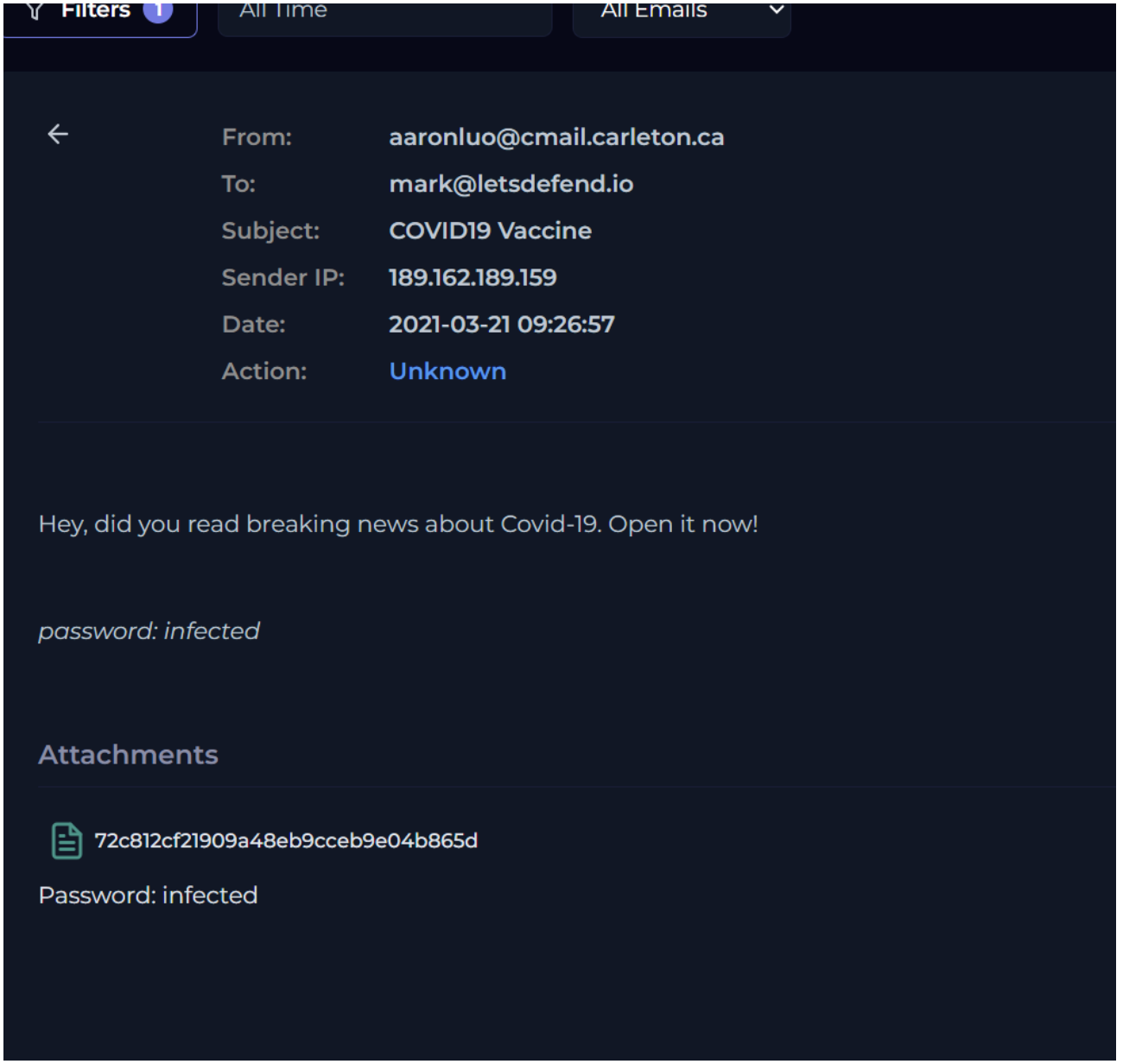
An SMTP destination identifies a mail handling system, not necessarily the recipient’s workstation. A clean history on that server does not establish that every recipient device is clean. Delivery status and endpoint coverage need to be checked separately for each related message.

Evidence 1 Alert and message details



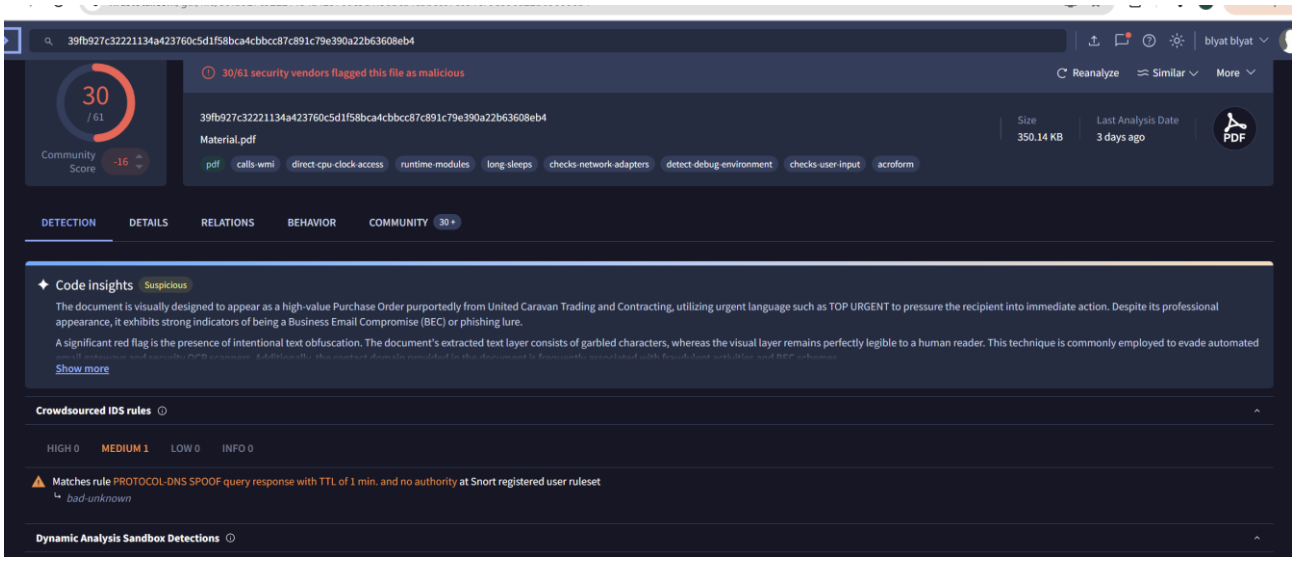
Evidence 2 Attachment reputation

Capture the file report summary with the complete digest, hash type, verdict, and analysis date. Add the second service's summary if available. Verify that both reports refer to exactly the same file before pairing them.



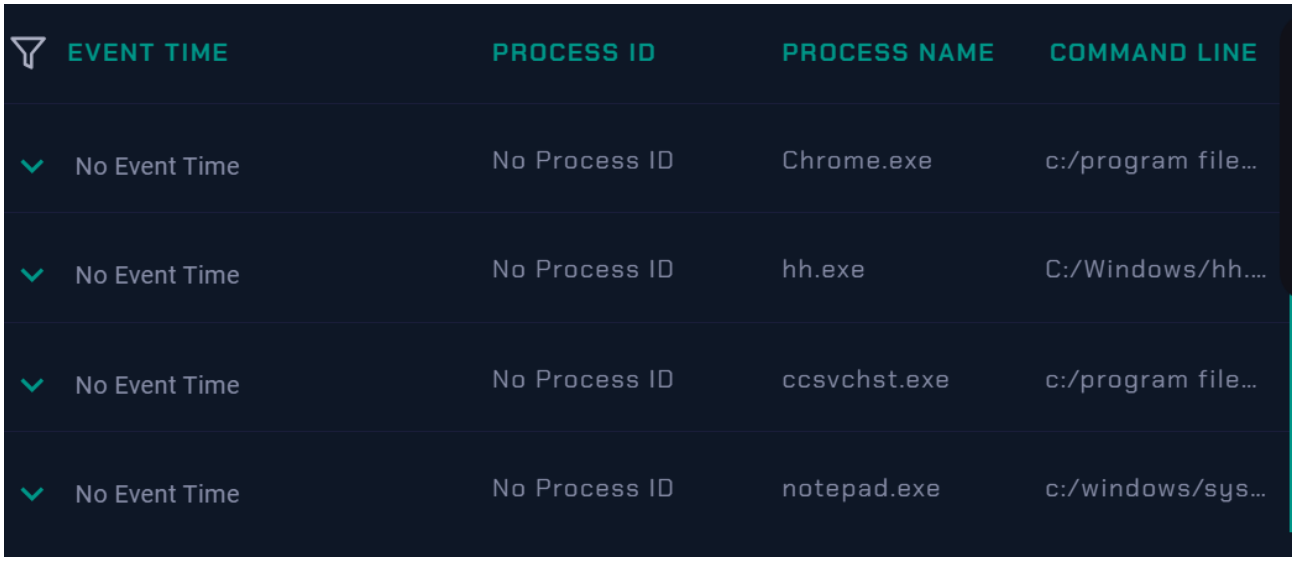
Evidence record for scope and execution

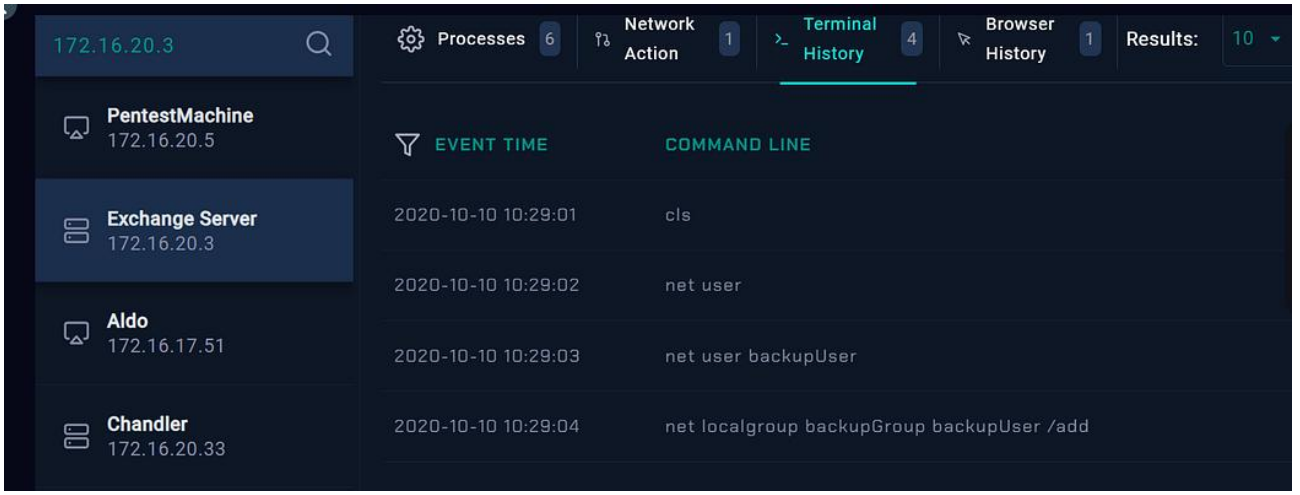
Evidence 3 Virustotal



Evidence 4 Host review and task validation

Capture the host identity and relevant process or command history, with the search window visible. If scheduled task evidence exists, add its definition and related execution events. Otherwise, state that task execution remains unconfirmed; do not use an empty results screen as proof of complete coverage.





Evidence handling note Add an evidence ID to each original export, record the collection time and timezone, and retain the files alongside the case notes. Use these IDs in the final closure entry.